A BOOMING CAREER

From discovery to his apotheosis as a great, these are notable performances/ benchmarks that have shaped Bumrah

2013

» Attending a Gujarat vs Mumbai T20 match in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, former New Zealand cricketer and Mumbai Indians coach John Wright is intrigued with a 19-year-old's "unusual action". Bumrah is signed on by Mumbai Indians after only one season of domestic T20 cricket

» Legend goes that when brought to the nets in Mumbai, Sachin Tendulkar tells Wright, "He's really hard to pick up"

2016

» Makes ODI and T20 international debuts for India. Playing Australia Down Under, he emerges the highest wicket-taker in T20s with 6 scalps

2017

» Highest wicket-taker for IPL champions Mumbai Indians, with 20 wickets

2018

» Makes his Test debut against South Africa. Gets a fifer in Johannesburg

» Flummoxes Australia with 6 for 33 and 3 for 53 in the Melbourne Test; ensures an unassailable 2-1 series lead for India in Border-Gavaskar series

2019

» Player of the match in low-scoring IPL final. Once again, the highest wicket-taker for MI with 19 scalps

2022

» Back injury rules him out of Asia Cup, T20 WC and the World Test Championship final in 2023

2023

» At the 2023 ICC Cricket World Cup, he claims 20 wickets, as India finish as runners-up

2024

» Takes 15 wickets with an unbelievable economy rate of 4.17 in the T20 World Cup-winning campaign. Adjudged Player of the Tournament

» In the 2024-25 Border-Gavaskar series, takes 32 wickets in 5 Tests at an astounding average of 13.06—the most by an Indian in an away series. Australia won 3-1, but Bumrah is Player of the Series

» Declared ICC's Men's Cricketer of the Year. He is Test Cricketer of the Year too

2026

» Wins player of the match in the T20 WC final. Also ends the tournament as the joint highest wicket-taker (14) alongside teammate Varun Chakaravarthy



GETTY IMAGES

Inside the Bumrah Mind

His fearless and consistent line of attack in the face of aggression has also proved to be a sound tactical move over the years. The age-old "you miss, I hit" formula never allows a batter the comfort of freeing his arms. Because unlike most others, Bumrah isn't looking for an escape route. It is this tactical acumen—coupled with exceptional skill and discipline—that makes him such an unbeatable package. What else explains his first-ball slower delivery to England's most feared batter, Harry Brook, in the semi-final of the ICC Men's T20 World Cup? Where conventional wisdom would suggest using a slower ball only as a follow-up to a pace-on good-length or short-of-length delivery, Bumrah—aware of Brook's attacking instincts—outwitted him from the very first ball.

"On occasions when Rahul (Dravid), Vikram (Rathour) and I were sitting in the dugout analysing the game, we would think maybe this is the delivery needed right now to dismiss a particular batter," recalls Mhambrey. "And then, to our surprise, he would execute that exact delivery. Almost every time. It's like someone reading your mind or overhearing your conversation. His ability to analyse the situation is very rare." No wonder Bumrah was once earmarked as India's next Test captain. And if not for the injuries that prevent him from playing year-round, he might well have added far more than just three Tests to his tally as India's captain.

The first and only bowler in cricket history to be No. 1 in all three formats at different points in time, he is, as captain Suryakumar Yadav calls him, a "once-in-a-generation bowler, a national treasure". "He knows what needs to be done, how it needs to be done...the best in the business," adds the skipper. But he is also something more. Former England pacer Steve Finn nails it: "Everyone else is mortal. There's good bowlers, there's great bowlers, then there's Jasprit Bumrah." Amen. ■